

ATI Radeon X800 XL

Waiting To Explode

Recently, ATi launched the Radeon X800 XL graphic card comprising a mammoth, 512 MB of memory. The card is based on the X800 XL (R430) chip which is manufactured using 0.11 micron technology unlike the 0.13 micron being used to produce the X800 XT and the X850 XT from ATi.

This PCI-Express card features dual DVI ports as well as VIVO via a composite port. It features the ATi Rage Theatre chip doing all the work.

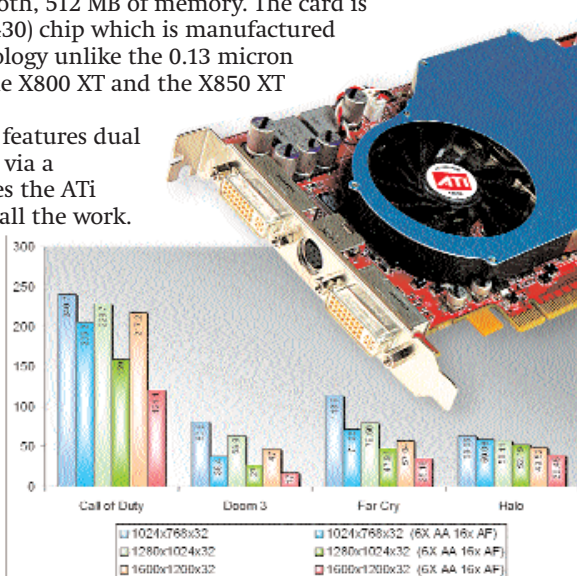
The fan speed is controlled by the drivers and even at maximum load, it was silent. It is a DirectX 9.0b card and has 16 pipelines. The chip is clocked at 400 MHz whereas the memory is clocked at 1 GHz.

The card was tested on a setup using a 3.6 MHz Pentium IV

Prescott processor on an original Intel 925XCV motherboard equipped with Micron 1 GB 533MHz DDR2 RAM running Windows XP SP1. The drivers were Catalyst 5.5. We wanted to see if the 512 MB framebuffer benefited any games. Not much at lower resolutions.

Coming to 3DMark05—often used as an yardstick in graphic performance—the X800 XL scored 5028 on default settings and an impressive 3994 on 1024 x 768 with all the effects cranked up.

The extra memory does not offer a performance benefit to justify premium pricing. You are better off holding on to your present cards!



Company **ATI Technologies**

Price **NA**

Web site **www.ati.com**

Rating **1 2 3 4 5**

Bose Wave Music System

Live Up Your Mornings

The Bose Wave Music System is a surprisingly compact device that functions as an Audio CD/MP3 CD player, FM/AM radio and an Alarm that wakes you each morning to the station or track of your choice, and speakers that'll give any high-end 2.1 system a run for its woofers.

These features are in a sleek black trapezoidal case—also available in platinum white. The centre of the front panel has a bright green display that tells the time, and other information like the ID3 tags in an MP3 CD. The overall look is retro, kind of like the radio alarms you'll see in Hollywood movies from the '80s, yet, has a sleekness about it that gives you an idea of the power beneath. The lack of buttons—all functions are only through its remote—and the slot-based CD underline the design.

The Wave is packed with some nifty features—automatic night-time dimming of its display, a gentle ramping of the volume to its final set position when you turn on the device so you're spared the rudeness of sudden loudness; a power cord that also doubles as an antenna. Thanks to its form factor, setting it up couldn't have been easier.

The sound is crystal clear and rich. Even at full volume, you'll be hard-pressed to find any distortion. Before you run to get this, though, take a look at the price—at Rs 30,000, it can only be called staggering!

Company **Bose Corporation India Pvt Ltd**

Price **Rs 29,990 + taxes**

Phone **011 - 2307 3825**

E-mail **nandita_sood@boseindia.com**

Web site **www.boseindia.com**

Rating **1 2 3 4 5**

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Mitashi DivX-999 DVD Player

Sometime earlier, we had reviewed the Mitashi DivX-555 player. Now, Mitashi has launched a sibling, the DivX-999. It is similar to the earlier launch but looks much sleeker and has a tray-less slot design. Yes, instead of a tray coming out of the player, you will have to insert the disc into the player.

It plays DVDs, Audio CDs, Video-CDs, MP3 and WMA CDs and DivX and XviD movies and more. Regrettably, though, not WMV files.

Build quality is good, although the remote looks tacky and the laminated keypad plastic soon starts coming off. The remote provides all functions to control the player. Playback quality is good and setup and menu is intuitive.

DivX and XviD playback is good, but if the movie confronts higher bit-rates for a MPEG 4 movie, it starts framing. DVD and Audio CD playback, though, is impeccable and yes, it does play HD-CD's.

The player offers 5.1-channel audio using analogue as well as digital connectivity options.

Overall, this is a good all-round player and the player is region-free, which will let you play DVD's from anywhere without a hitch.

Company **Mitashi Edutainment Pvt. Ltd.**

Price **Rs 4,990**

Phone **022 25006661**

E-mail **rakesh@mitashi.com**

Web site **www.mitashi.com**

Rating **1 2 3 4 5**

1 Poor: Has serious drawbacks and needs improvement before it can be used for its target application. **2 Mediocre:** Does not live up to expectations, needs improvement in many areas. **3 Average:** Reasonably competent but nothing spectacular about the product. **4 Good:** A good buy, better than most products in its category. **5 Excellent:** A brilliant combination of price, performance and features - far beyond expectations.